



Anxiety Disorders

Anxiety is, in fact, a natural emotion that helps people protect themselves in the face of danger. However, when this emotion becomes excessive, intense, and difficult to control even in the absence of an actual threat, it can significantly affect an individual's life. This is when anxiety disorders emerge. According to the World Health Organization, anxiety disorders affected approximately 359 million people in 2021, making them one of the most prevalent groups of mental disorders worldwide. Symptoms may often begin during childhood or adolescence and are more frequently observed in women than in men.

An individual experiencing an anxiety disorder does not merely feel "worried." Intense fear and persistent worry may be accompanied by physical symptoms such as restlessness, tension, difficulty concentrating, sleep disturbances, muscle tension, sweating, trembling, nausea, and palpitations. Individuals often begin avoiding situations that make them uncomfortable in an attempt to reduce their anxiety. Although this avoidance may appear relieving in the short term, in the long term, it can further reinforce fear and lead to restrictions in the individual's academic, occupational, family, and social life.

Anxiety disorders do not constitute a single disorder. In generalized anxiety disorder, an individual experiences excessive and prolonged worry about multiple aspects of everyday life. In panic disorder, unexpectedly occurring intense panic attacks and fear of experiencing another attack are prominent. In addition, social anxiety disorder, characterized by intense fear of being evaluated or embarrassed in social situations; specific phobias, characterized by excessive fear of particular objects or situations; agoraphobia, characterized by fear of places where escape or obtaining help may be difficult; and separation anxiety disorder, characterized by excessive fear related to separation from attachment figures, are also included within this group.

It is particularly important to distinguish panic attacks from panic disorder. A panic attack is an

episode of intense fear or discomfort that can reach its peak within several minutes. It may produce symptoms such as palpitations, sweating, trembling, shortness of breath, chest pain, dizziness, numbness, nausea, and fear of dying or losing control. Consequently, an individual may sometimes believe that they are experiencing a heart attack or that they are going to die. However, experiencing a single panic attack does not necessarily mean that the individual has panic disorder. In panic disorder, recurrent attacks are accompanied by persistent concern about experiencing another attack for at least one month or behavioral changes intended to avoid further attacks.

There is no single cause of anxiety disorders. Genetic predisposition, brain systems associated with fear and anxiety, psychological characteristics, and stressful or adverse life experiences may all contribute together. Therefore, it is not accurate to tell an individual experiencing an anxiety disorder that they are simply "overthinking." At the same time, anxiety symptoms may also be associated with certain physical illnesses or the use of substances and medications. For example, thyroid disorders, certain cardiac and respiratory conditions, caffeine, or certain medications may produce symptoms resembling anxiety. Therefore, for an accurate diagnosis, symptoms should be evaluated not only from a psychological perspective but also, when necessary, from a physical perspective.

During diagnosis, the onset, duration, frequency, and degree of impact on daily functioning of the individual's symptoms are assessed. In generalized anxiety disorder, it is an important diagnostic criterion that excessive anxiety persists on most days for at least 6 months and that the individual has difficulty controlling the worry. In panic disorder, recurrent and unexpected panic attacks, together with persistent concern or behavioral changes that develop following these attacks, are taken into consideration. Because depression, substance use disorders, and other mental disorders may frequently coexist, assessment should be conducted comprehensively.

An important aspect of anxiety disorders is that they are treatable. Among the most effective

treatment options are psychotherapy and, when necessary, pharmacological treatment. In particular, cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) helps individuals recognize anxiety-provoking thoughts and their responses to these thoughts and enables them to cope with feared situations in healthier ways. In panic disorder, exposure-based techniques, particularly those involving controlled confrontation with bodily sensations, may also be used. When necessary, selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors (SSRIs) and serotonin–norepinephrine reuptake inhibitors (SNRIs) may be effective treatment options. Benzodiazepines, however, are generally not preferred as long-term or first-line treatments because of risks such as dependence, tolerance, and withdrawal.

In conclusion, anxiety disorder is not a simple condition that can be explained by an individual being “weak” or “making things up in their head.” The fear system may become excessively activated even when there is no actual danger, affecting an individual’s thoughts, body, and behavior. Nevertheless, with appropriate assessment, suitable psychotherapy, pharmacological treatment when necessary, and healthy lifestyle habits, symptoms can be brought under control. Therefore, when intense anxiety begins to interfere with daily life, seeking professional help rather than ignoring it is an important step toward regaining the individual’s quality of life.

References :

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